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SOLIDIFYING GLOBAL ACTION IN RESPONSE TO THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC-

THE POLITICS OF COVID
VACCINES AND IMPLICATIONS
FOR DEVELOPING COUNTRIES



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TABLE OF CONTENT

- 4. INTRODUCTION**
- 5. THE
CORONAVIRUS
DISEASE**
- 6. THE GLOBAL
COVID-19 VACCINE
ALLIANCE INITIATIVE**
- 7. GLOBAL GOVERNANCE
WEAKNESSES-THE
CONCEPTION**
- 8. THE CHALLENGES AND
POLITICS OF COVID-19
VACCINE DEVELOPMENT
AND DISTRIBUTION**
- 9. COVID-19 AND SOCIO-
ECONOMIC IMPLICATIONS
ON VACCINE ACQUISITION
BY DEVELOPING COUNTRIES**
- 10. CONCLUSION &
RECOMENDATION**

ABSTRACT

Giant strides have been made in the fight against the coronavirus disease (COVID-19), especially in the area of vaccine development. However, countries that made investments in vaccine production are concerned with the vaccination of their citizens leaving developing countries and other vulnerable groups to their fate. The paper focused on how the global action against the COVID-19 pandemic could be strengthened especially in the area of vaccine distribution to benefit developing countries and vulnerable groups that have been neglected. The World Health Organization and the GAVI initiative launched to cater for these groups have also moved at a much slower distribution pace due to lack of funding and effective participation of wealthy countries. These challenges interestingly persist in global governance institutions and continue to hinder their effectiveness. The paper recommends that global initiatives should be welcomed with necessary resourcing and funding since they are crucial to protecting lives as well as livelihoods of the vulnerable groups in the world.

INTRODUCTION

The novel coronavirus disease has had a grip on the world, affecting almost every aspect of life and every continent. After a year of its outbreak, the world is still in limbo regarding the thawing of the virus. This has not only been a global health crisis, it has had an adverse impact on the global economy. The number of people infected by the virus surpassed a 100 million, with more than 2 million lives lost to the disease (Worldometers, 2021; Sanyaolu et al, 2021). A United Nations Development Program (UNDP) report estimates a loss of US\$220 billion in revenue to developing countries since the outbreak (UNDP, 2021), while the International Labour Organization (ILO) estimates a global job loss of 400 million due to the pandemic (ILO, 2020). Sectors such as education, technology, security and social life have not been spared. In education, a staggering 1.6 billion students around the world were out of school due to lockdowns and other restrictions at the height of the pandemic in 2020 (Laureates and Leaders for Children, 2020; Engzell et al, 2021). COVID-19 has indeed caused a colossal loss to the world.

Since 2020, efforts have been geared at developing vaccines to curb the disease. Mostly, these initiatives have emanated from developed countries and private international institutions that are at the forefront in the fight against COVID-19. While few countries are leading the effort in vaccine development, production and distribution, many developing countries are only waiting for the outcomes of the developed countries' initiatives (Felter, 2021). Since the focus of developed countries is centred on the vaccination of their citizens, the politics of national interest has taken pre-eminence over global solidarity. The implication of this phenomenon on developing countries is enormous. While COVID-19 keeps ravaging and contracting economies, developing countries have to wait until the objective of vaccine producing countries becomes trade or more preferably, aid.

This paper focuses on how the global efforts in the fight against COVID-19 could be strengthened vis-à-vis the politics of the prioritization of vaccines and the implication for developing countries. The paper also proffer recommendations on how lessons learnt in the COVID-19 health crisis could help developing countries to develop resilience strategies by strengthening their political and economic systems.

THE CORONAVIRUS DISEASE

The severe acute respiratory syndrome coronavirus-2 (SARS-CoV-2) has had a global impact, being the fifth pandemic since the flu pandemic of 1918 (Yen-Chin et al, 2020). The first record on the outbreak of the disease occurred in December, 2019, in Wuhan city, China. On 11th March, 2020. The WHO declared COVID-19 as a pandemic, following the 1918 Spanish flu (H1N1), 1957 Asian flu (H2N2), 1968 Hong Kong flu (H3N2), and 2009 Pandemic flu (H1N1), which caused an estimated 50 million, 1.5 million, 1 million, and 300,000 human deaths, respectively (Yen-Chin et al, 2020). The source of the COVID-19 is not completely lucid; however, the disease is transmitted either by COVID-19-positive persons or from a COVID-19 infected environment (Rahman et al, 2020). At the outset, the infection was understood to be caused by animal-to-human transmission without animal species association. Subsequently, it was found that human-to-human transmission was the commonest mode of viral spread because a growing number of patients without a history of exposure to the market had acquired the disease (Rahman et al, 2020). The signs of COVID-19 infection are mild to severe with high mortality probability in some cases. Commonly known symptoms include lower respiratory tract infection, pneumonia, dry cough, fever, shortness of breath, dyspnea, and myalgia. Headache, confusion, sore throat, hemoptysis, runny nose, chills, muscle and chest pain, rhinorrhea, and diarrhea with nausea and vomiting may occur but less commonly reported (Rahman et al, 2020). It has also been established that patients can be infected with the virus without showing any of the above symptoms. Many of the COVID-19 cases, however have good prognoses with mild symptoms, and with supportive care, they recovered after 7–10 days of hospitalization (Rahman et al, 2020).

GLOBAL GOVERNANCE WEAKNESSES-THE CONCEPTION

The world has not realised the full intents and meaning of the term global governance. Global governance is a loosely defined term derived from the establishment and operation of institutions founded through agreements of nations and other transnational cooperation to perform specific functions in favour of the parties or signatories to such agreements and to provide solutions to challenges of national and transnational nature (United Nation, 2014). The notion of global governance appears to be less specific, more intricate, and hence even harder to pinpoint (Hofferbeth, 2016).

The first attempt at transnational cooperation was at the Westphalian conference in 1648, where states came into agreement to sign the treaties of Westphalia which also signalled the first attempt towards a universal peace and cooperation. Patton (2019), argues that the Peace of Westphalia is the origin of principles crucial to modern international cooperation. The idea of international cooperation emanates from the idealists thinking in international relations. Although idealism does not completely call for a global government, it advocates for a high level of cooperation between countries which could culminate into a full global governance system (Nuruzzaman, 2008). International cooperation advocates that efforts and attention given to the resolution of national issues should be given to international problems as well. In essence, it calls for solutions to international problems as a collective activity or as a global response. The impediments to the full realisation of global governance are partly embedded in the formations and establishments of global governance systems and institutions. The inability of global governance institutions to respond to global challenges effectively is primarily inherent in their design and conceptual frameworks. In fact, Coen and Pegram (2015) argue that global governance is not working. In the fight against the coronavirus disease for instance, the weaknesses in global governance institutions are revealed. The Global Alliance For Vaccine Immunization (GAVI) project is the world's action against the pandemic. Haass (2020) however explains the challenge in its implementation that apart from the COVID-19 Vaccines Global Access (COVAX) effort lacking adequate funding, the participation of the United States and China is also lacking. Developed and wealthy countries are looking inwardly instead of fully supporting the global action yet they are members of the global body, WHO. These challenges and their handling by the WHO in the long run confirm the foundational challenge of global governance institutions regards real global efforts in handling of global problems.

THE GLOBAL COVID-19 VACCINE ALLIANCE INITIATIVE

The Global Vaccine Alliance, with the World Health Organization (WHO) as one of its main stakeholders, is the world's main effort in the vaccination against the coronavirus disease. This initiative is supposed to cater for some 92 low and middle income countries (GAVI, 2020). The initiative became imperative as wealthy and developed countries focused on vaccinating their citizens leaving the fate of developing countries in their own hands. Until the Conception of this initiative, the global response to the pandemic was limited to advocacy and sharing information and guidelines by the foremost global governance institution, the WHO. The global health body is charged with the responsibility of providing leadership in dealing with global health issues. The overwhelming response by countries to the outbreak of COVID-19 shattered the idea of global cooperation, but promoted national survival or security. Governments implemented stringent measures such as the closing territorial borders, revealing how weak and loose the global governance system is. In the wake of the coronavirus outbreak and widespread, regional organizations like the European Union and Africa Union, went against their objectives and closed borders to their members in 2020 (Holden, 2020). This is the extent to which the Coronavirus disease affected world groupings and regional organizations. The GAVI project, however, is a beam of light not only to developing countries in their gravest moments but also a measure of the enormous potentials of global governance institutions in responding to global crises. Even though distribution is at a much slower pace, it would have been gloomier for developing countries if there was no global vaccine development and distribution effort. The WHO has put forward a global allocation framework that seek to ensure priority for the most vulnerable populations and health-care workers (Haass, 2020). It is not far-fetched to conclude that global actions seek to cater for vulnerable groups and promote equity and equality. Hence, this paper is advocating for strengthened global institutions to respond effectively and efficiently to global crises.

THE CHALLENGES AND POLITICS OF COVID-19 VACCINE DEVELOPMENT AND DISTRIBUTION

The COVID-19 pandemic has resulted in the most rapid vaccine development timeline the world has seen (Andreadakis et al, 2020). Traditionally, the cycle of vaccine development takes more than 10 years (Plotkin, 2011). However, this has not been the case of COVID-19 vaccines. The world has been forced to fast-track the production of COVID-19 vaccines to deal with the ravages of the disease. Governments, multilateral organizations and private firms have spent billions of Dollars to develop effective vaccines just a year after its outbreak (Felter, 2021). Although the efforts of these groups are commendable, they have favoured sovereignty global action against the pandemic.

Vaccine nationalism, as postulated by (Haass, 2020), has a greater impact on developing countries. Since many developing countries lack the capacity to develop vaccines, those developed countries remain their only hope. There is a global effort to develop and distribute effective vaccines, some results have come in. Sadly, these initiatives, are nationally focused. Countries are interested in developing vaccines for their citizens as opposed to a global concerted effort.

The competition and geopolitical preferences of COVID-19 vaccines presents a worrying situation for developing countries. Developing countries have had to wait until citizens of developed countries are vaccinated. Over a hundred efforts in vaccine development are underway with a number of them already in use. The Pfizer-BioNTech, Moderna and Johnson & Johnson/ Janssen vaccines are some of the widely approved COVID-19 vaccines in use. The toughest problem is the issue of access. As discussed by (Chatterjee et al, 2021), some of the questions have to do with who receives the initial doses of developed vaccines as a small contingent of wealthy countries- Australia, Canada, Japan, the United Kingdom, the United States and the European Union are already scrambling for them. Would access be limited to allies of vaccine producing countries while the population of developing countries perish? Another likely problem is the distribution of COVID-19 vaccines and whether they could be given as Aid to poor countries. Addressing these questions are key as developing countries remain vulnerable due to economic wreck caused by the COVID-19 pandemic and the risk of being exploited by wealthy countries. While some developing countries are yet to receive a single dose of a COVID-19 vaccine, some wealthy countries like the United Kingdom, United States of America and Canada have acquired doses 150 to 500% of their predicted needs (Ekström et al, 2021). The inequalities in vaccine distribution clearly present a worrying situation for global concern. Against this backdrop, this study analyses the effects of the inequalities presented by the politics of the vaccine development and distribution.

COVID-19 AND SOCIO-ECONOMIC IMPLICATIONS ON VACCINE ACQUISITION BY DEVELOPING COUNTRIES

COVID-19 has had a ravaging socio-economic effect on developing countries. As at the time of this research, a UNDP report estimated a revenue loss of \$ 220 billion to developing countries due to the COVID-19 Pandemic (UNDP, 2020). The impact of COVID-19 on developing countries is huge. Past gains have not only be eroded, it would take several years to be achieved again. For instance, in Sub-Saharan African countries, COVID-19 has affected the basics of life (Amewu et al, 2020). Countries that resorted to social distancing, travel restrictions and economic lockdowns to curb the spread of the Coronavirus disease did so at a huge economic expense. The socio-economic cost of these harsh measures are expected to be even high, especially in Sub-Saharan Africa where many live “hand-to-mouth” with little or no social safety nets ((Amewu et al, 2020).

The economic projections of many developing countries by the beginning of the year 2020 became impossible policy dilemmas. The GDP of Ghana, for example, fell by more than 27% and more than 3 million of its citizens became poor during its 3-week lockdown period in 2020 ((Amewu et al, 2020)). Another palpable example is the economy of Nigeria. Before the pandemic, the country was recuperating from a recession. The economy began to show promising signs but the pandemic made it worse (Lenon, 2020). The government projected a fall in oil revenues (Nigeria’s biggest source of revenue) of more than 70% (Lenon, 2020). This severely affected the government of Nigeria as many sectors of the economy depend on the oil industry. A third example is Kenya. By stressing countries like Kenya, the pandemic created a long-term devastating social, economic and political crises is leaving deep scars (UNDP, 2020). The real GDP growth of Kenya fell to 1.5 percent in 2020, a huge fall from 5.4 percent measured in 2019 (Faria, 2021). The endgame of these analyses aim to indicate that the fight against COVID-19 in developing countries could be lost due to the already weakened states of their economies.

While developed countries have invested huge resources into the development of vaccines, developing countries are already exhausted with little to spend on the vaccination of their citizens. A solidified global action against COVID-19 is a more desirable solution to developing countries

CONCLUSION

The pandemic has re-echoed the weaknesses in global responses witnessed by the politics in the production and distribution of COVID-19 vaccines. As exposed by the COVID-19 pandemic, developed nations look inward in times of crises to deal with national security, leaving poorer countries to their fate. This is evidenced by the various vaccine development and distribution efforts and strategies. The paper revealed that developed countries prioritize the safety of their citizens instead of supporting a global concerted effort to dealing with the crises. This factors weaken the operations of global governance institutions and also tend to promote huge inequality gaps between developed countries and developing countries. The implication is that poorer countries suffer the most in the absence of global actions hence the need for them to be strengthened.

RECOMMENDATION

From the analyses above, the following are highly recommended:

1. Global initiatives should be supported with necessary resources and funding as they are functional to the eradication of inequalities in the world.
2. COVID-19 Vaccine Aid: Vaccines distributed to developing countries should be given as Aid. The ravages of the COVID-19 pandemic put many developing countries in positions that make vaccine acquisition a huge burden on them. It is therefore recommended that the global effort should be resourced by wealthy countries to enable vaccines to be given to developing countries as aid.
3. Developing Countries should take a cue from the lessons learned from the coronavirus pandemic to invest in health research based institutions that would serve as national health crisis responses even before a global action is mobilized.
4. Global institutions must be strengthened to facilitate global actions. This comprises granting global governance institutions the power to operate and function without countries sabotaging their efforts by refusing to ratify binding agreements countering their efforts.

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